



2026–2030 BEYOND TODAY



Strengthening the Future-Picture: The
Next-level for Growth and Resilience



WELCOME



When you think about where we're headed as people and begin to wonder where your place is in this world, you would be responsible to consider the distant past. The United States fought a full war known as the "Civil War" and never punished the people who joined the "Confederacy," also known as the Confederate States (C.S.), or the South. The Confederacy was an unrecognized breakaway republic in the Southern United States from 1861 to 1865. The Confederacy comprised eleven U.S. states including Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, Florida, Mississippi, Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, Arkansas, and Tennessee who all declared succession. If people had been punished accordingly, we wouldn't have the talk or hallmarks of "fascism" (the "radical left," "socialism" or the "other") today across the U.S. The lesson: when things happen to white Americans, it opens the eyes of everyone to strike down fascism regardless of what we're being told but witnessing with our own eyes. Renee Nicole Good killed by an ICE officer demonstrates the hallmarks of fascism and totalitarianism (coercion and repression), which brings me to this issue titled "Strengthening the Future-Picture: The Next-level for Growth and Resilience." Amazing how a country can change in 12-hours on Friday, 09 January 2026. What can you do if you had longer? Review and enjoy.



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These segments are based solely on the insights published by our Skipper at the Bison Group® team using the AxeusSM Platform at the TriplicitySM Solutions.



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WHAT IT MEANS TO STRENGTHEN TOMORROW?

Everyone, regardless if they're in business or not, must be wondering what this time in America means to them? **"Strengthening the Future-Picture: The Next-level for Growth and Resilience"** brings us to a time where every individual's action matter. We're at a time similar to the mid-1800s where people had to make a choice. President Calvin Coolidge famously stated, "The business of America is business," and today, American businesses remain essential, employing around 136M people—nearly half with small companies. For decades, businesses prioritized economic and technological issues over geopolitics, but now geopolitical risks are seen as the biggest threat to growth. Recent tariffs between the U.S. and China, along with the tariff changes in 2025, have introduced unprecedented uncertainty for American businesses and their supply chains. As the cornerstone of the global economy, the U.S. must foster strong government-business collaboration to navigate evolving challenges in trade, economics, and security. But what does it really mean to grow the next level?

As the U.S. starts 2026, trends and events have positioned themselves, although one of us can't make progress like all of us. Trends come and go, and what consumers want often changes to improve behavior and outcomes. While business momentum can rise and fall, the requirement to move forward—by adapting and innovating—remains constant. Yet progress is rarely simple. It relies on having a reliable team with proven experience and the ability to use advanced technology. Such a team must possess strong expertise and essential skills, enabling organizations to tackle even the toughest challenges. Setting and exceeding objectives is increasingly complex. Integrating AI and innovating at scale require new skills, insights, and collaboration. That's why leaders form multidisciplinary teams and seek diverse perspectives to drive progress. It's important to partner closely with organizations to create solutions that enable digital transformation and future-specific growth, blending technology with proven business expertise.

WHAT IT MEANS TO STRENGTHEN TOMORROW?

So, what does it all mean? Although the Future-Picture is very uncertain and business in the United States haven't seen growth since mid-2025 (and probably won't until late Q3), **organizations must have the right resources, at the right time, for all the right reasons to survive beyond 2026!** For example, organizations should combine deep sector experience, advance analytics, and keep deploying (or start) digital innovation to help teams solve their most complex operational challenges. These actions will help achieve lasting competitive advantage and resilience in rapidly changing markets—and they are changing. And leaders can start by conducting a comprehensive assessment of current and unforeseen inventory levels and service offerings—connecting the dots between inventory mix problems and ongoing best-practices to improve Customer-facing Experience (CX) service levels.

Harmonizing the two functions—and bringing inventory management up to date—would take a strategic course correction. It would take a data-driven approach that would reduce excess inventory, increase service levels, improve team collaboration, and align directions. With these principles in mind, team development with a multi-year roadmap could address both technical and human challenges. The outcome could develop a fresh inventory management approach that's not only effective, but also scalable to be adapted throughout the organization. And while work in this area proceeds, cash flow concerns could start to ease. The new paradigm of data-powered decision-making can reduce the organization's maximum inventory targets and reorder points (the specific level at which new orders should be placed) by significant amounts, freeing up capital for other investments. The organization could also identify other cost savings simply by canceling purchase orders that are no longer needed due to cancelling work orders or marketplace changes.

This is just one example of your “what” and “how.” This is what change, or improvement to affect tomorrow. What are you doing?

STRENGTHENING THE FUTURE-PICTURE...

As I move into the next segment, **“Strengthening the Future-Picture: Growth and Resilience,”** things are rapidly changing, shifting from traditional strategy delivery to technology-driven, AGILE, and execution-focused, heavily influenced by AI, digital transformation, and hybrid work models. As a leader, are you really watching the marketplace to understand what’s actually happening? Are you shifting from being an advisor to a valuable partner, delivering specialized skills and solutions, outcome-based pricing, and a move from billable hours to tangible results that can be counted on for a long period of time? This change is the “Voice-of-the-Customer” (VOC) today. Are you listening?

With years of industry maturity and experience, you can seamlessly unlock actionable, qualitative insights across extensive quantitative datasets—no long probing or complex conversations—only real work that matters. With fresh or newly developed frameworks, organizations can break down problems, outline plans, and take action without being prompted by a user. They can also strengthen the Future-Picture and achieve the next-level for growth and resilience. **Leaders must ask questions, surface trends, and generate decision-ready context in very short timelines in the world of AI.** Growth must operate at a pilot scale, while working with business operations of ALL types and sizes, and listen carefully to their needs, NOT their wants, to create smarter operations. Be fundamentally about improving individuals and organizations by fostering critical thinking, broadening opportunities, reducing disparities, and empowering people to build Better-Best communities and a more just world. Use features to impact the user or customer's satisfaction based on distinguishing between **four needs** that create excitement and helps the individual or teams focus resources on features that truly matter to deliver the most value. Obsessing over customer needs, four of them, is crucial for several reasons:

STRENGTHENING THE FUTURE-PICTURE...

Building “Next Level Organizations (NLOs)” that is based on fulfilling building business growth, enhancing customer satisfaction, and driving innovation that’s different MUST be achieved in the age of AI.

Business Growth:

Understanding and meeting customer needs is crucial for business growth. By seeing things from the customer’s perspective, organizations can ensure satisfaction, which leads to:

- **Higher retention:** satisfied customers are more likely to return and keeping them costs much less than acquiring new ones.
- **More recommendations:** loyal customers often refer others, broadening your brand’s reach.
- **Greater lifetime value:** fulfilling customer needs increases long-term revenue by retaining customers longer.

Enhancing Customer Satisfaction:

Research and our outcomes since 1996 shows that meeting or exceeding customer needs directly boosts customer satisfaction. Key benefits include:

- **Build trust and loyalty:** customers feel valued when their needs are addressed, leading to long-term business and ongoing revenue.
- **Reduces churn:** consistently resolving issues keeps customers loyal and reduces loss to competitors.

Driving Innovation that’s Different:

Organizations that consistently address customer needs remain competitive. Customers shape which products succeed and highlight how you can improve or create new offers:

- **Identifies market gaps:** understanding customer needs reveals unmet areas, presenting opportunities to offer desirable products and services.

STRENGTHENING THE FUTURE-PICTURE...

Driving Innovation that's Different (cont.) ...

- Helps you stay competitive: responding to customer feedback keeps your business relevant and ensures continued demand.

Anticipating customer needs is challenging, but meeting them early increases satisfaction, eases customer service demands, and sets your business and organization apart.

Earlier it was said that four basic needs are used to build "Next Level Organizations" (NLOs), which are (with examples) "PN (Personal Need: health)," "BN (Basic Need: norms)," "EN (Excitement Need: eBikes)," and "PdEN (Performance-driven Execution™ Need: expectations)." These four are used to guide development and build essential features, improve key ones, and disruptively innovate with surprising additions. Again the "voice" matters if we only listen intently to hear what's being "said" and "not spoken." Think about Lean Six Sigma on the next-level.

Conclusion

In summary, these four architectures: "Next Level Organizations" (NLOs), which are (with examples) "PN (Personal Need: health)," "BN (Basic Need: norms)," "EN (Excitement Need: eBikes)," and "PdEN (Performance-driven Execution™ Need: expectations)," aim to improve individuals, organizations, and businesses by promoting critical thinking, expanding opportunities, reducing disparities, and empowering communities. They prioritize features that meet key needs to maximize value and user satisfaction.

Understanding customer needs requires ongoing effort and a culture focused on the customer. By consistently tuning into and adapting to these needs, organizations can exceed expectations and foster lasting customer satisfaction. Try them and let us know how they're working. Your input will help us make them better to improve the Future-Picture and the "Voice-of-the-Customer" (VOC).

FINDING THE RIGHT PEOPLE IN THE ERA OF GEOPOLITICS

In today's highly interconnected, post-pandemic, and Artificial Intelligence (AI) environments, talent acquisition has moved beyond the traditional scope of human resources. It now extends to navigating a complex landscape shaped by evolving power structures that does a great job of explaining "VUCA-BANI:" Volatility-Uncertainty-Complexity-Ambiguity-Brittle (easily breakable)-Anxious (heightened emotional strain)-Non-linear (disconnected cause-effect)-Incomprehensible (overwhelming information) to everyday people. VUCA-BANI was popularized by the work of Jamais Cascio, but we do the job of breaking it down for people on the outside of business. It suggests that VUCA is the norm and BANI better captures the deep instability and emotional toll of today's world.

Factors such as trade disputes, military conflicts, ideological changes, and social-political instability have become significant considerations in hiring processes. This marks the emergence of a new era in global talent management—one influenced as much by geopolitical developments as by professional qualifications. Earlier, we talked about how business in the U. S. haven't seen growth since mid-2025 and probably won't until late Q3 but technology have seriously hurt the hiring and onboarding process because it removed the "human element" from the process. People's attention-spans are very short today, hence VUCA-BANI. Understanding people needs and expectations comes down to a few things:

The Politicization of Visas and Work Permits

Immigration policies are changing as increases of protectionism makes it harder for talent to move internationally. Nations are also implementing stricter measures to retain their workforce. HR teams must now closely to monitor visa rules, since job offers depend on legal relocation or residency. Some events like Brexit have disrupted labor flows requiring organizations to adjust hiring strategies.

FINDING THE RIGHT PEOPLE IN THE ERA OF GEOPOLITICS

Nearshoring and Friend shoring: Hiring with Political Alignment in Mind (cont.) ...

As trade becomes a battleground—witness U.S.-China tensions or sanctions on Russia—organizations are responding with nearshoring (moving operations closer to home) and friend shoring (outsourcing to politically aligned nations). This trend affects manufacturing, logistics, and talent strategy, with organizations creating teams in regions offering stability, beneficial taxes, and shared values. Latin America, Eastern Europe, and Southeast Asia are increasingly chosen for tech and back-office friend shoring.

Uncertainty is Reshaping Talent Pipelines

As political, environmental, and economic shocks continue to influence project execution, the most resilient organizations across the U.S. and world will be those that treat talent planning as a strategic imperative, not a reactive task. The concept of a sustainable workforce has evolved in today's environment. Instead of simply ensuring a constant flow of talent, organizations now focus on creating agile systems that stay resilient during disruptions and still deliver results. For many organizations, this involves reevaluating recruitment strategies, strengthening regional centers, expanding the range of candidate sources, and prioritizing expertise in international compliance.

Conclusion

In today's business environment, hiring is no longer a transactional process but serves as a critical strategic function. Organizations that leverage talent intelligence—integrating geopolitical considerations, VISA regulations, and regional workforce trends—achieve a distinct competitive advantage. Whether in the U.S. or experts in other countries throughout the world, organizations must approach talent acquisition with the strategic acumen of experienced diplomats.

SELF-AWARENESS IS THE CORNERSTONE FOR LEADERSHIP 2.0

As I journey into the “people” section of the series, **“Self-Awareness is the Cornerstone for Leadership 2.0,”** this part makes me think about the people on our team. I have deep conversations with my friend and colleague in NYC whose been doing hiring and search since the 90s. He tells me all of the time how AI has removed the human element from the hiring process. He says “people don’t take a few minutes to actually write cover letter. It’s as if they lost self-awareness.” This is the cornerstone for Leadership 2.0; yes, leadership has graduated!

Leadership 2.0: The Future of Leadership Development

Leadership development is experiencing significant transformation as organizations worldwide address emerging challenges and opportunities. In today’s climate, characterized by rapid technological progress, heightened global connectivity, and evolving workforce dynamics, workplace education and self-awareness has progressed toward a new model: Leadership 2.0. This advancement involves a fundamental reassessment of leader preparation, training, and development, rather than merely rebranding existing programs. We’ve completed an enormous amount of research on a topic that we’ve been heavily focusing on since the mid-90s. With years in the U.S. Marine Corps severing several unfortunate battlefields, this section examines the future trajectory of leadership development by analyzing key trends influencing self-awareness and Leadership 2.0.

Transitioning from Traditional to Experiential Learning

Historically, leadership has emphasized classroom and workforce instruction, case study analysis, and theoretical frameworks. While these approaches retain value, current business conditions require more adaptable and hands-on learning methodologies.

SELF-AWARENESS IS THE CORNERSTONE FOR LEADERSHIP 2.0

A notable development in Leadership 2.0 is the movement toward immersive experiences that enable leaders to implement insights directly within their organizational context. To focus on this dilemma, we created the **FAST**-Galloping GhostSM and focused on self-awareness.

Boost Self-awareness with the Disruptive Differentiation StrategySM (DdS)

Our research prioritized the development of the **FAST**-Galloping GhostSM framework, emphasizing prevalent leadership challenges across all organizational levels. The majority of our findings were sourced from the Center for Creative Leadership in Greensboro, NC (ccl.org), and our team implemented the Disruptive Differentiation StrategySM (DdS) to guide leaders in adapting their behaviors to address this multifaceted topic. This raised an essential question: “where is the appropriate starting point?” Facilitating the development of self-awareness among leaders presents a viable initial step.

Consider instances where leaders demonstrated insufficient self-awareness—such cases are frequently encountered. Studies indicate that only approximately 15% of individuals possess adequate self-awareness, with less than a 30% correlation between actual and self-perceived competence. Moreover, these findings reveal that a lack of self-awareness among leaders adversely affects decision-making, collaboration, and conflict resolution. Self-awareness, which is integral to Emotional Intelligence (EQ), represents a foundational element within the DdS framework. It empowers leaders to gain comprehensive insight into their own characteristics and the effects they have on others. Leaders who exhibit robust self-awareness can effectively recognize their emotions, identify strengths and developmental areas, and make informed decisions when faced with complex scenarios.

SELF-AWARENESS IS THE CORNERSTONE FOR LEADERSHIP 2.0

To foster self-awareness, organizations should instruct all people to leverage the components of the Disruptive Differentiation StrategySM (DdS) as introduced by our team. But first, they have to ask themselves **“what is self-awareness really?”** Self-awareness is a major differentiator in the Leadership 2.0 framework. Individuals operate within communities, societies, organizations, and families, making interpersonal interactions essential to daily life. Building effective relationships relies on cultivating self-awareness, which allows one to understand, anticipate, and manage their own actions and responses. This capacity not only enhances personal and professional relationships but also supports optimal functioning within groups. In the business environment, success extends beyond strategy, profitability, and innovation; it fundamentally includes self-awareness—a deep understanding of oneself and the impact of one’s actions.

Such awareness enables more informed decision-making, fosters stronger relationships, and drives sustainable growth. Ultimately, self-awareness is instrumental to achieving organizational and individual objectives.

How can leaders enhance their self-awareness? Self-awareness plays a vital role in business leadership. By understanding their own strengths and areas for growth, leaders are equipped to make informed decisions, foster effective teams, and cultivate strong professional relationships. Developing self-awareness is an ongoing process that involves thoughtful reflection, actively seeking constructive feedback, and demonstrating openness to personal and professional development. Leaders can begin by evaluating their capabilities, welcoming input from colleagues, and pursuing continuous improvement—benefiting both themselves and their organizations.

SELF-AWARENESS IS THE CORNERSTONE FOR LEADERSHIP 2.0

The Broader Impact on Leadership and Team Dynamics

Organizational leadership—particularly within the framework of Leadership 2.0—presents multifaceted challenges. The rapid pace, elevated stakes, and ongoing decision-making processes can prove demanding even for experienced business leaders. Nonetheless, self-awareness remains a critical yet sometimes undervalued attribute that significantly improves one's ability to manage these complexities. Far from being solely a personal trait, self-awareness is indispensable for professional achievement. It enables individuals to recognize their strengths and areas for growth, foster authentic relationships, and execute decisions with greater clarity and intent.

This section examines a pivotal role of self-awareness in organizational development and offers guidance for business leaders striving to cultivate this essential quality as part of their path to implementing Leadership 2.0. Cultivating self-awareness produces far-reaching benefits for both individuals and organizations. The following illustrates its impact:

- **Stronger Leadership:** leaders who are self-aware build trust and earn respect. By embodying empathy, humility, and authenticity, they establish workplace cultures where employees feel appreciated and engaged.
- **Improved Decision-Making:** a heightened awareness of individual biases and tendencies leads to decisions that are more considered and strategically sound.
- **Enhanced Team Performance:** understanding and adapting one's leadership style to suit the team optimizes group potential.
- **Resilience in Adversity:** entrepreneurial ventures frequently encounter obstacles; self-awareness equips leaders to address these challenges with composure and professionalism.

SELF-AWARENESS IS THE CORNERSTONE FOR LEADERSHIP 2.0

Creating a Mindful Workplace

Leadership sets the standard for organizational culture. By promoting values such as mental wellbeing and mindfulness, leaders contribute to environments where employees flourish. Effective initiatives include:

- **Leading by Example:** sharing mindfulness practices and encouraging employee participation.
- **Providing Resources:** supplying access to mental health services, comprehensive wellness programs, and mindfulness workshops.
- **Facilitating Open Communication:** supporting transparent dialogue so team members feel secure when addressing difficulties or seeking assistance.

A workplace that embraces mindfulness promotes not only better health among employees but also enhanced productivity and innovation.

Conclusion

If you haven't graduated your leadership efforts to Leadership 2.0, then you're in a place that you don't want to be. Personal conduct and professional outcomes demand both internal reflection and external action. Cultivating self-awareness empowers people to act with increased clarity, purpose, and resilience. This pursuit is characterized by progress rather than perfection, necessitating commitment, patience, and an openness to personal growth. The resulting advantages—to individual development and overall business outcomes—are substantial. Initiating with small demanding steps, maintaining consistency, and valuing ongoing development will equip people to transition to leaders to propel themselves, their organizations, and their businesses toward continued success.

IS THE SAME STILL THE NORM OR HAS IT CHANGED?

As I move into the next segment, REASONABLE people have to be asking themselves **“is the same still the norm or has it changed drastically?”** Am I a victim of my own doing? Have my eyes deceived me? Where exactly do I stand on the issues today? These questions must be asked and answered before moving forward. I’ve noticed that people now casually use a phrase that feels surprisingly new: “I’m finding myself.” This isn’t about being lost in a strange neighborhood, it’s about searching for values, identity, direction, the whole internal GPS recalibration. Today, this idea is so ingrained that we rarely question it; it’s almost respectable to say you’re “finding yourself” during times of transition.

What strikes me is how recent this seems, culturally speaking. My parents never said it, nor did my grandparents who were born in the early years of the 1900s. That doesn’t mean they didn’t feel lost, they just described their struggles differently: through duty, obligations, roles, faith, or simply by keeping quiet. The language they used shaped their actions for better or worse.

I’m thinking about this because of the general atmosphere; not the loudest, most dramatic voices, but a tense undercurrent. Even online in social media or platforms like Facebook or LinkedIn, there’s an edgier tone, more certainty, more “if you disagree, you’re showing your true colors.” This isn’t a complaint about the various platforms; I think it reflects how, when the world felt more safety. Now it feels unstable where professionals reach for easy narratives and quick conclusions. And things do feel unstable: Iran, Israel and Palestine, Israel and everybody else, Venezuela, Ukraine and Russia, China and Tiwan, tariffs, Trump, unemployment, geopolitics, race and gender, and more—shifting power, business changes, weakening institutions, and AI technology amid it all. So yes, people are looking inward. Which brings me back to the questions in my opening or my key question: “is the same still the norm or has it changed drastically?”

IS THE SAME STILL THE NORM OR HAS IT CHANGED?

There's nothing new with conflict or unemployment. There is no crisis or disaster—rather, a subtle recognition that current circumstances are no longer entirely suitable. You must adapt or change with the times. This situation frequently arises among individuals and professionals who have consistently met expectations: they have earned promotions, demonstrated competence, and achieved stability. Nevertheless, a sense of unease persists. Such feelings should not be interpreted as failure; instead, they are often an indication to pause and reflect, not necessarily to increase efforts but to carefully consider one's next steps. Remember, everyone has shit. Oh well, nobody cares. It doesn't make yours any easier because you're living it but "shit happen, it's your turn!" Most challenges and problems don't live on the surface but appear when you voice your opinion and add to the experience. The key is to enhance the experience to make it better by other people regardless of your situation.

Conclusion

"The struggles we endure today will be the 'good old days' we laugh about tomorrow."—Aaron Lauritsen, author. How many times has this happened in your lifetime? While comfort is valued today, it can hinder progress by fostering complacency and limiting creativity. Discomfort signals growth, pushing us beyond routine and encouraging new experiences. Set objectives that challenge you without causing overwhelming tasks and seek feedback to foster development. Pain lets you know you're alive! Treat failure as a learning opportunity, adjust strategies, and try again. Explore unfamiliar activities and perspectives to expand your adaptability. It's okay to go down a different road to see where you'll end up. Embracing discomfort is vital; it drives personal and professional advancement, turning unease into a guide for breakthroughs.

WHY IT ALL MATTERS?

Our “Beyond Today” issue titled, “Strengthening the Future-Picture: The Next-level for Growth and Resilience,” focuses on embracing tomorrow to accept the new normal. So far with the issues, the theme has been “resilience.” **My Key Takeaways are:**

- Resilience, alignment and innovation will be the three defining characteristics of Leadership 2.0 beyond 2026.
- In today’s complex personal and professional environment, people and teams are going to be more important than ever, even in this technological era. In addition to providing a “head-first attitude,” people are a useful resource in times of uncertainty and help propel innovation and resilience as well.
- To strengthen personal and professional growth in 2026 and beyond, it’s important to take a fresh look at your current circumstances, invest in talent development, involve others, and inspire leadership that’s graduated to develop a growth mindset regardless of the situation.

As we approached 2025, uncertainty grew with both challenges and opportunities. Economic and technological shifts forced people and leaders to rethink resilience and adapt for long-term success. Today’s people and leaders must anticipate change, act quickly, and foster innovation. Strong, resilient leadership—Leadership 2.0—is essential for thriving in a fast-evolving market. Here are ways people and organizations can build resilience, stay ahead, and achieve lasting success in 2026 and beyond:

- **Prepare for Uncertainty:** advances in AI, extreme operation patterns, and political changes have demonstrated that even well-constructed plans may require adjustment. Strategic planning remains essential, but leaders must also cultivate humility.

WHY IT ALL MATTERS?

- **Foster Organizational Resilience:** challenges are unpredictable especially the “current (the future), the gaps (the Event Horizon) and the desired outcome (the Future-Picture),” which are critically important; however, organizations can strengthen their foundations by prioritizing values, culture, and community, enabling them to respond flexibly to change.
- **Recognize the Limits of Certainty:** nonprofits often rely on long-term strategic plans, yet adaptability proves more effective than rigid adherence. Develop plans thoughtfully, remain receptive to change, and adapt as needed.
- **Lead with Humility:** acknowledging both personal and organizational limitations fosters collaboration and sustainability. Leadership is strengthened when teams recognize that success requires collective effort using a graduated form of leadership to remain competitive or on top.
- **Emphasize Optimism:** while global challenges persist, maintaining hope is critical. Identify and build upon positive developments to encourage balanced optimism within the organization. As Thich Nhat Hanh noted, “no mud, no lotus.”
- **Act Promptly:** stressful circumstances may provoke hesitation; however, organizational missions depend on proactive decision-making. Advance through incremental, strategic actions while continuing to learn and adapt using continuous transformation (evolution).
- **Prioritize Contextual Awareness:** historical precedents are less predictive than ever before. Attentiveness to context allows organizations to identify trends, avoid misinformation, and make informed decisions.
- **Commit to Continuous Learning:** technological advancements, including AI, are altering established norms FAST. Cultivating curiosity and a commitment to ongoing education enhances Organizational Excellence (OpEx) and performance.

WHY IT ALL MATTERS?

- **Continuous Transformation (evolution) is Critical:** change performance (outcomes) to Performance-driven Execution™ (PdE); everything graduates and changes for the better.
- **Reaffirm Purpose:** amidst disruption, reconnecting with core purpose preserves focus and motivation. The original inspiration behind the work provides essential guidance during challenging times.
- **Adopt a Long-term Perspective:** meaningful progress requires sustained effort over generations. Even if immediate results are not visible, each contribution supports continued advancement and legacy-building.
- **Lead Strategically Despite Fear:** fear can impede clear judgment. Recognizing its presence allows leaders to prioritize thoughtful strategies over reactionary impulses, exemplifying effective leadership.

Conclusion

While these principles are longstanding, their relevance has increased significantly. The year 2026 will present new challenges; however, people, teams, and organizations can approach them with enhanced experience and awareness over time. By moving forward with clarity and intention, people and leaders can maximize their impact within available opportunities.

2026 brings new challenges, but we're better prepared and more grounded than last year. Let's stay focused and make the most of our time, and let's learn more throughout the year and into 2030. Our "why" matters; make it count.

You should finish this issue, as we point out "inspiring women in the world" to watch and follow in 2026 and beyond, specifically Sanae Takaichi, the first female Prime Minister of Japan.

ONE MORE THING: MY BONUS TO YOU!

“Run the World (Girls)” is a dynamic anthem from Beyoncé’s fourth studio album, 4 (Deluxe Edition), which debuted in 2011. The track is widely recognized for its uplifting message of female empowerment and self-reliance, cementing its place as an influential work in today’s music landscape. In an era characterized by rapid transformation, innovation, and unpredictability, certain women are not only adapting to future developments but are actively contributing to them. **“Inspiring Women to Follow in 2026 and Beyond”** features a diverse group whose work is shaping advancements in politics, science, technology, leadership, education, security, governance, and social impact.

Spanning laboratories, boardrooms, classrooms, government institutions, and international platforms, these individuals have leveraged their expertise to effect meaningful change and address significant challenges within their respective fields. Here’s some of them:

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi (the Iron Lady)

Japan’s first-ever female prime minister (2025), Sanae Takaichi, is a conservative with a traditional view of gender roles and an admirer of the late former UK PM Margaret Thatcher.

VA Governor Democrat Abigail Spanberger (D, 2025)

Abigail Spanberger is the first woman elected to lead the commonwealth since it became a state in 1788, elected to the U.S. House of Representatives in 2018, and a former intelligence officer.

NJ Governor Democrat Mikie Sherrill (D, 2025)

Rebecca Michelle “Mikie” Sherrill is a politician, former naval officer and former federal prosecutor, and a graduate of the United States Naval Academy in Annapolis, Maryland.

Mayor Cherelle Parker (D, 2024)

Cherelle Parker became the 100th mayor of the City of Philadelphia and the first woman to lead the city and hold the office in 341 years.

ONE MORE THING: MY BONUS TO YOU!

President Claudia Sheinbaum (2024)

Claudia Sheinbaum, PhD, is a climate scientist and former mayor of Mexico City. She is Mexico's first-ever woman president, first Jewish person to hold the office, and the 5th most powerful woman in the world.

Dr. Subhadra Dravida

Dr. Subhadra Dravida, who is redefining biotechnology and ethical drug discovery through human stem cell innovation and AI-driven Micro Physiological Systems.

Dr. Charmaine KM Yan

Dr. Charmaine KM Yan, whose work at the intersection of quantum technologies, AI, and biotechnology-driven wellness is shaping the future of longevity, healthcare, and advanced tech ecosystems.

Dr. Priscilla “Dr. P” Kucer

Dr. Priscilla “Dr. P” Kucer, whose evidence-based business methodologies help micro and small businesses scale sustainably.

Sridevi Edupuganti

Sridevi Edupuganti who stepped away from corporate comfort to build ZenithWorks.AI and prove that AI-powered transformation and human wellbeing can rise together.

Australian Gina Field

Gina Field has broken barriers in the security industry, building one of the most awarded firms in her sector while championing women in non-traditional careers.

Dr. Jacqueline Kucera

In the realm of public leadership and policy, Dr. Jacqueline Kucera is shaping informed governance as Head of the Parliamentary Library, Research, and Parliamentary Data for the Swiss Parliament, while advocating for women in AI and responsible innovation on a global stage.

ONE MORE THING: MY BONUS TO YOU!

Adriana E. Torres Nava

Adriana E. Torres Nava brings more than three decades of experience to her role at Capgemini's Mexico Global Delivery Center, redefining nearshoring while using education and entrepreneurship initiatives to uplift underserved communities.

Lieda Shadwick

As a CTE educator and DECA advisor, Lieda Shadwick turns business and entrepreneurship into lived experiences for her students, nurturing confidence and real-world readiness that extend far beyond the classroom.

Robyn Mussler

Robyn Mussler's work through platforms such as SharkMakers creates pathways for young people to become innovators, problem-solvers, and purpose-driven leaders, grounded in accessibility and empathy.

Dr. Sujaya Banerjee

And through Capstone People Consulting, YourCommune, and the Women Leadership Forum of Asia, Dr. Sujaya Banerjee is helping organizations across Asia build people-first cultures while opening doors for women to rise into leadership with purpose, empathy, and vision.

Other women to watch in 2026 and beyond are already changing the face of global leadership. Moreover, their influence stretches from cockpits to cabinet rooms. As a result, old barriers are falling faster than ever before. There are more but I'm pointing them out in this issue to go far beyond their titles and achievements. Early influences, defining decisions, risks taken, barriers challenged, and the values that continue to guide these women show what to come. As you move through their journeys, you will find not just inspiration, but practical insight into what it truly means to lead with courage, clarity, and conviction.

ONE MORE THING: MY BONUS TO YOU!

Power Rising: More Women to Watch in 2026

Aviation Takes Flight with Women to Watch

First, meet **Joanna Geraghty, CEO of JetBlue**. She became one of the first women to watch at the helm of a major U.S. carrier. Since taking the role, she has balanced profit with passenger happiness. For example, she expanded transatlantic routes while cutting costs. Additionally, she pushed sustainable aviation fuel across the fleet. Therefore, thousands of female pilots and engineers now see a real path forward. Geraghty proves that women to watch can lead even the toughest industries.

Meanwhile, across the Pacific, **Mitsuko Tottori leads Japan Airlines**. She is the first woman president in the airline's 73-year history. Yet her style is calm and collaborative. After the pandemic, she rebuilt international routes step by step. At the same time, she kept Japan's famous on-time record intact. Because of her success, Japanese companies face new pressure to promote women. Thus, Tottori quietly shows why women to watch matter in traditional corporate cultures.

Tech and Finance: The Next Women to Watch

Next, look at technology and finance. Several women to watch are already CFOs or COOs of giant firms. For instance, **Ruth Porat at Alphabet** and **Jane Fraser at Citigroup** have set the standard. Now, boards demand diverse shortlists for every CEO opening. Consequently, 2026 will likely see at least three more female CEOs in Fortune 500 tech and banking giants.

Finally, diverse leadership works better. Studies show women in top roles outperform peers by 25–35%. Moreover, countries with higher female representation in parliament pass more laws on healthcare and education. So, when women reach the top, everyone benefits. I encourage you and everyone to think bigger, act bolder, and believe more deeply in the impact one determined woman can make.

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